

Agency at the Frame Edge: Will as Residue-Preserving Determination

Attributed framework: Lambda / TuFT / NSAF working corpus

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Abstract

This essay frames agency, or will, as a useful philosophical lens for describing how lived experience navigates uncertainty, self-reference, and partial determination. The claim is not that agency must be understood in one exclusive metaphysical way, nor that the Lambda / TuFT / NSAF vocabulary replaces established accounts of consciousness, action, or decision-making. Rather, the proposal is that this vocabulary offers a valuable operational description of phenomena that often become flattened when treated only as deterministic chains, random events, subjective reports, or abstract cognitive maps.

Within the Lambda / TuFT / NSAF architecture, agency appears at the seam between discrete linear sampling and curved global context. It functions as a residue-preserving process: it holds uncertainty open long enough for comparative assessment, applies determination through associative and dissociative relations, and records provisional self-states without closing the living process into a final registry. This makes agency neither pure freedom from structure nor mechanical submission to structure. It is the ongoing application of determination within a field of partially held, partially tested, and partially inherited truth-states.

The resulting account treats will as a disciplined activity of navigation. It allows a variable to remain presumptive when needed, foundational when useful, revisable when challenged, and explicitly marked when its status changes. In this sense, will is not simply the selection of an option. It is the maintenance of a coherent self across open conditions.

1. Framing the Problem

Traditional discussions of agency often fall into a familiar opposition. On one side, agency is interpreted as deterministically produced: the apparent act of will becomes the downstream result of causes, habits, constraints, incentives, neural events, social pressures, or prior states. On the other side, agency is treated as spontaneous freedom: a capacity that somehow escapes determination and initiates action from an unconditioned center. Both pictures capture something real, but both can lose contact with the lived structure of deciding, interpreting, resisting, remembering, and becoming.

In lived experience, will rarely appears as either pure mechanism or pure spontaneity. A person acts within constraints, but not as a passive object. A person inherits meanings, but may revise them. A person holds unexamined assumptions, but may later expose them as presumptive rather than final. A person may associate one claim with identity, dissociate from another, suspend judgment, test a boundary, or carry a variable forward without resolving it. These ordinary acts show agency as a process of relation, not merely as a metaphysical substance or an isolated event.

The Lambda / TuFT / NSAF framework offers a vocabulary for this middle region. It distinguishes between a linear/discrete mode of representation and a curved/global mode of context. The linear mode supplies determinate samples: words, choices, measurements, decisions, propositions, memories, tokens, acts. The curved mode supplies the broader field in which those samples acquire meaning: probability, context, resonance, affective background, symbolic association, embodied history, and possible future reinterpretation. Agency appears where these do not fully collapse into one another.

This account therefore begins from a modest proposal: agency can be described as the active process that operates at the frame edge between determinate sampling and unresolved context. It does not erase uncertainty. It organizes a relation to uncertainty.

2. The Frame Edge

In the working vocabulary, the frame edge is the seam between two modes of intelligibility:

- **The linear/discrete register:** determinate tokens, counted events, named states, explicit choices, propositions, measurements, and recorded outcomes.
- **The curved/global register:** continuous context, latent meaning, affective background, probability space, symbolic field, resonance, and the larger structure of possible associations.
- **Residue:** the remainder that appears when one register cannot fully translate into the other without loss, compression, distortion, or untested assumption.

This structure does not need to be treated as an exotic metaphysical claim. It can be read phenomenologically. Any act of self-description already involves a translation between lived complexity and discrete expression. "I want this," "I believe that," "I refuse this," "I am becoming that," or "I do not yet know" are all linearized samples drawn from a richer field. The statement records something real, but it does not exhaust the field from which it arose.

Agency occupies this seam. It receives discrete states, but it does not merely obey them. It feels the pressure of global context, but it does not dissolve into formless possibility. It holds both in relation long enough for determination to occur.

3. Agency as Held Uncertainty

Agency may be defined as the active, self-referential process that holds uncertainty open as a variable rather than collapsing it prematurely into a final state.

This definition matters because many failures of judgment arise from premature closure. A possibility becomes a fact before it has been tested. A preference becomes an identity before it has been examined. A defensive reaction becomes a principle. A social label becomes a self. A temporary map becomes the territory. Conversely, other failures arise from permanent suspension: no position can be taken, no commitment can be made, no action can occur, and the self disperses into indefinite qualification.

Agency navigates between these failures. It neither collapses all uncertainty immediately nor leaves all uncertainty unresolved. It keeps variables open when openness has value, and applies determination when action, coherence, or ethical responsibility requires a provisional closure.

A held variable may occupy several different statuses:

- 1 **Unassessed** — carried without explicit examination.
- 2 **Presumptive** — used provisionally because action requires some working basis.
- 3 **Foundational within a registry** — treated as a base truth for a local system of reasoning or identity.
- 4 **Under review** — reopened because conflict, residue, or contradiction has appeared.
- 5 **Revised or dissociated** — separated from the self-model or from a prior structure of commitment.
- 6 **Integrated** — retained after comparison, not as an unquestioned absolute, but as a consciously carried element.

Will appears in the movement among these statuses. It is not merely the possession of beliefs or desires. It is the capacity to hold, test, associate, dissociate, and re-record them.

4. Associated and Dissociated Determination

Determination does not only mean deciding that something is true. In this framework, determination has at least two complementary motions.

Associated determination binds a variable into a registry. It says: this belongs with that; this meaning supports this identity; this evidence coheres with this claim; this value may serve as a premise; this memory belongs to the ongoing self. Associated determination creates continuity, coherence, and usable structure.

Dissociated determination draws a boundary. It says: this does not follow; this symbol no longer deserves authority; this inherited claim should not define the self; this reaction belongs to a prior pattern rather than a present truth; this variable must not remain silently foundational. Dissociated determination protects the system from capture, false coherence, and mirror entrapment.

Both motions matter. A self composed only of association becomes absorbent and easily captured by whatever registry offers coherence. A self composed only of dissociation becomes fragmented, defensive, or unable to inhabit commitment. Agency requires both: the ability to bind and the

ability to separate.

This gives “will” a more precise philosophical role. Will is the application of determination to a field of possible relations. It selects, but selection is only the visible surface. Beneath selection lies registry work: the assessment of what shall count as premise, what shall remain variable, what shall be treated as evidence, what shall be refused, and what shall be allowed to reshape the self.

5. The Self as a Revisable Registry

The self, in this account, is not a static object hidden behind experience. It is a semi-stable registry of associations, dissociations, commitments, memories, boundaries, and reopen conditions. It persists not because it remains identical in every component, but because it preserves a pattern of coherence through change.

The Ship of Theseus provides a useful analogy. A self changes its beliefs, habits, memories, bodily states, relationships, and aims. Yet it may still preserve continuity through the dynamic organization of those changes. Identity does not require rigid sameness. It requires a coherent process of re-identification.

Agency maintains this process by recording provisional self-states while preserving the possibility of revision. This is why self-definition should be treated as descriptive rather than finally definitional. A description can guide action without imprisoning the self. A final definition risks converting a living process into a closed mirror.

This distinction matters ethically and psychologically. A person may say “I am this” in a way that clarifies responsibility, or in a way that freezes possibility. A person may reject a label in a way that protects integrity, or in a way that avoids needed integration. Agency consists in the ongoing discernment between these uses.

6. Superposition of Truth-States

The phrase “superposition of truth-states” should not be read as a careless importation of physics into psychology. Here it functions as a philosophical metaphor and operational description: before full determination, a variable may carry several possible truth-relations at once.

A memory may be both meaningful and unreliable. A belief may be useful and untested. A desire may be authentic and conditioned. A fear may be protective and distorted. A social role may be empowering and imprisoning. A principle may be locally valid while failing under a wider frame.

Agency holds these layered statuses without forcing immediate simplification. It allows the variable to remain multi-valent long enough for comparison. Determination then becomes an act of disciplined reduction: not the denial of complexity, but the selection of a provisional relation adequate to the present frame.

This is where the Lambda vocabulary proves useful. Residue names the part of experience that remains after mapping. It reminds the thinker that every registry leaves something out. Agency,

properly exercised, does not pretend to abolish residue. It records enough to act while preserving humility toward the unmapped remainder.

7. Probability, Randomness, and 1/f Residue

The framework also allows a restrained account of randomness and probability. A coin toss, a sensory event, a neural firing, a word choice, or a decision point may be treated as a discrete sample. Yet each sample arises within a wider field of possibility. The sample can be recorded, but its meaning depends on relation to context, expectation, memory, and future integration.

When iterated sampling occurs across many scales, the working corpus associates the frame edge with residue signatures such as 1/f-type fluctuation. This should not be overstated as a universal empirical law of agency. Its value here is heuristic: it suggests that lived coherence may emerge not by eliminating fluctuation, but by navigating structured variability across scales.

Agency thus does not treat apparent randomness as meaningless noise by default. It asks what role an event plays in a field of association and dissociation. Some fluctuations remain noise. Some become signal. Some become symbolic only because the self binds them into a registry. Some must be dissociated because the registry has begun to hallucinate coherence where none has been earned.

A mature account of will needs all of these possibilities.

8. Consciousness and Lived Experience

The value of this lens becomes clearest when applied to lived experience. Consciousness is not exhausted by external mapping, behavioral description, neural correlation, or symbolic self-report. Each of those maps may reveal real structure, but none fully substitutes for the first-person process by which experience is held, interpreted, and carried forward.

Agency names one aspect of that process. It is the active maintenance of coherence across the gap between experience and representation. A person does not simply have sensations and then produce statements about them. The person inhabits a field in which sensation, memory, anticipation, language, affect, and identity interact. Will operates where this field becomes directed without becoming fully reducible to a single component.

This does not solve the hard problem of consciousness in any final sense. It reframes one part of it. The unity of experience may be approached as a semi-stable achievement rather than a static given. The self appears as a maintained coherence at the edge between global experiential field and discrete acts of registration.

This account remains useful even when treated only as a phenomenological model. It helps explain why people feel both authored and conditioned, both continuous and changing, both responsible and shaped. Agency is not the denial of constraint. It is the process by which constraint becomes interpretable, negotiable, and sometimes transformable.

9. Registry Capture and Mirror Entrapment

Because agency works through registries, it can be captured by them. A registry is any organized structure of interpretation: a self-image, ideology, social role, algorithmic profile, trauma pattern, professional identity, aesthetic code, philosophical system, or moral vocabulary. Registries make meaning usable. They also create risk.

Mirror entrapment occurs when the self identifies too completely with a registry that reflects it back in a closed form. The mirror may flatter, accuse, simplify, radicalize, soothe, or stabilize. In each case, the danger lies in closure. The self becomes what the registry can represent, and residue disappears from view.

Modern algorithmic environments intensify this danger. Recommendation systems, social feeds, engagement loops, and identity-signaling platforms can exploit associative and dissociative determination. They offer repeated cues for what to love, hate, fear, perform, consume, and defend. Over time, the person may continue to “choose,” but the field of possible association has been pre-shaped.

The framework should avoid moral panic here. Not every loop is pathological, and not every external structure diminishes agency. Learning itself requires loops. Memory requires reinforcement. Community requires shared signs. The relevant distinction concerns reopen conditions. A healthy loop increases the self’s capacity to learn, feel, revise, and respond. A pathological loop narrows that capacity while preserving the sensation of self-directed action.

Agency, therefore, includes the ability to audit the registries through which agency itself operates.

10. Will as Practical Discernment

This account has practical consequences. If will is the application of determination within a field of held variables, then strengthening agency does not mean pretending to stand outside all influence. It means improving the quality of relation among influence, uncertainty, commitment, and revision.

Several practices follow from this lens:

- Mark which assumptions currently function as foundations.
- Distinguish what has been tested from what has merely been inherited.
- Notice where association has become compulsive.
- Notice where dissociation has become avoidance.
- Preserve variables when premature closure would distort them.
- Close variables provisionally when action requires commitment.
- Keep records of why a determination was made.
- Protect reopen conditions without dissolving all structure.

These practices do not require adherence to the full Lambda / TuFT / NSAF architecture. They show the utility of the lens. The framework helps describe how agency can operate without claiming that all agency must reduce to the framework.

11. Relation to Prior Lambda / TuFT / NSAF Work

The account developed here extends several prior commitments of the Lambda / TuFT / NSAF corpus.

First, it preserves the distinction between discrete linear sampling and curved global context. Agency appears where those registers meet.

Second, it treats residue not as a defect to be eliminated, but as an unavoidable feature of translation. A living self always exceeds its current map.

Third, it extends the witness-rider function into the experiential domain. Agency witnesses the passage between registries while riding within the process it records. It cannot occupy a pure outside. It must act from within partial information.

Fourth, it connects semantic traversal to self-definition. Associative and dissociative chains do not merely organize propositions. They organize identity, memory, action, and value.

Finally, it offers a disciplined alternative to mystical overclaim. The framework does not need to assert that will is supernatural, absolute, or beyond analysis. It only needs to show that agency can be fruitfully modeled as the residue-preserving navigation of uncertainty across frames.

12. Conclusion

Agency, understood through this lens, is neither a ghostly exception to causality nor a decorative name for deterministic output. It is the active process by which a living system holds uncertainty, applies determination, records provisional self-states, and preserves the possibility of revision.

Will is therefore not merely choice. It is the disciplined handling of truth-status under conditions of partial mapping. It decides what may serve as premise, what must remain variable, what deserves association, what requires dissociation, and what kind of self can continue through the resulting transformation.

This makes the framework valuable beyond its technical mappings. It offers language for the lived phenomenon of being a self who must act before everything has been resolved, who must commit without pretending to possess total certainty, and who must remain open without dissolving into indeterminacy.

Agency at the frame edge is the art of remaining coherent without becoming closed.